“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Madhya-līlā

Chapter 25

Making the Residents of Kāśī Vaiṣṇavas, and the Return to Nīlācala

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 The Lord made Vaiṣṇavas of the residents of Kāśī, headed by the sannyāsīs; He fully purified Sanātana, and then He went to Nīlādri.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura![1]

3 In this way, for two months, Mahāprabhu taught him the conclusions of bhakti to their utmost depth.

4 Paramānanda Kīrtanīyā, the companion of Candraśekhara, would sing kīrtana for the Lord with great delight.

5 When the sannyāsīs disregarded the Lord, mercy towards them arose in Him, so that He might dispel the sorrow of His devotees.

6 I have described the Lord’s mercy to the sannyāsīs before, in detail. Here I mention it again, briefly.

7 Everywhere the sannyāsīs blasphemed the Lord. Hearing this, a brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra reflected sorrowfully:

8 “Whoever sees the Lord’s nature at close hand perceives who He truly is and accepts Him as Īśvara, the Supreme Lord.

9 If by some means I can bring them together, the sannyāsīs will see this and become His devotees.

10 I live in Vārāṇasī all the time. If I do not do this, I shall grieve for ever.”

11 Thinking thus, he invited all the sannyāsīs. Then that brāhmaṇa came to the place where Mahāprabhu was staying.

12 At that time Candraśekhara and Tapana Miśra, pained to hear the blasphemy, made their appeal at the Lord’s feet.

13 Seeing His devotees’ sorrow, the Lord reflected within Himself, and the wish arose in Him to turn the hearts of the sannyāsīs.

14 Just then the brāhmaṇa came and invited Him. With great humility he clasped the Lord’s feet.

15 Mahāprabhu then accepted his invitation, and the next day, after His midday duties, He went to his house.

16 I have already told in detail, in the account of the Pañca-tattva, how the Lord delivered the sannyāsīs there.

17 To tell it again would only lengthen the book; so here I write only what I did not write there.

18 From the day the Lord showed mercy to the sannyāsīs, the whole town was astir.

19 Crowds of people came to see the Lord, and scholars learned in various scriptures came to discuss scripture with Him.

20 Refuting every rival reading of the scriptures, the Lord established bhakti as their essence, and with well-reasoned words He turned everyone's mind.

21 Accepting His instruction, they performed kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana; all the people laughed, sang and danced.

22 The sannyāsīs bowed down to the Lord. Giving up their studies, they held discussions among themselves.[2]

23 One of Prakāśānanda's disciples, his equal, spoke in the assembly in praise of the Lord:

24 "Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya is Nārāyaṇa Himself. He explains the meaning of the *Vyāsa-sūtra* most charmingly.

25 He explains the primary meaning of the Upaniṣads, and hearing it soothes the minds and ears of the learned.

26 Abandoning the primary meaning of the sūtras and the Upaniṣads, the Ācārya (Śaṅkara) insists on his own imaginings.

27 When a scholar hears the meaning the Ācārya imagined, his mouth says 'Yes, yes,' but his heart does not accept it.

28 I accept the words of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya as firmly true: in the age of Kali one does not conquer *saṁsāra* by sannyāsa.

29 The explanation He gave of the *harer nāma* verse is true; its meaning gives joy, and it is the supreme evidence.

30 The *Bhāgavata* says that without bhakti there is no liberation, and in the age of Kali liberation comes easily by *nāmābhāsa*, the mere semblance of the holy name.[3]

31 "O almighty Lord, bhakti to You is the path to the highest good. Those who reject it and toil only to gain knowledge are left with nothing but their toil, like those who pound empty husks." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.4)[4]

32 "O lotus-eyed Lord, others think themselves liberated, but their intelligence is impure, for they have no love for You. Though they rise with great hardship to the supreme position, they fall down from there, having neglected Your feet." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.2.32)[5]

33 The word 'Brahman' means Bhagavān, full of the six opulences. To establish Him as without attributes (*nirviśeṣa*) is to diminish His completeness.

34 The śrutis and the Purāṇas speak of the play of Kṛṣṇa's spiritual potency (*cic-chakti-vilāsa*). Not accepting this, the scholar mocks it.[6]

35 To regard Kṛṣṇa's form of spirit and bliss as *māyic* is a great sin. Caitanya's words are true.

36 "O Supreme Lord, I see nothing higher than this form of Yours, which is pure bliss, free of all difference, its radiance unobscured. You are the one creator of the universe, yet You are distinct from it, O Self, and You are the source of the elements and the senses. I have taken shelter of that form of Yours." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.9.3)

37 "O good of all the worlds, for our good You have shown this very form to us, Your worshippers, in meditation. We bow down to You, Bhagavān,

whom those bound for hell, attached to false arguments, do not honour." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.9.4)[7]

38 "Fools disregard Me when I appear in a humanlike form, not knowing My supreme nature as the great Lord of all beings." (Bhagavad-gītā, 9.11)

39 "Again and again I cast those envious, cruel and impure men, the lowest of mankind, into the cycles of birth and death — into demonic wombs." (Bhagavad-gītā, 16.19)

40 Not accepting the doctrine of transformation (*pariṇāma-vāda*) taught in the sūtras, he establishes *vivarta-vāda*, saying that Vyāsa was mistaken.

41 Such an imagined meaning does not appeal to the mind. Abandoning the scriptures, he explains his wicked fancies to the *pāṣaṇḍīs*.[8]

42 Inquiry into the highest truth is gone; we only argue. How shall we gain liberation, and how Kṛṣṇa's grace?

43 The Ācārya has covered the meaning of the *Vyāsa-sūtra* — so says Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, and His words are true.

44 Whatever Caitanya Gosāñi says is the essential doctrine; all other doctrines are worthless."

45 Having said this, he began kṛṣṇa-saṅkīrtana. Hearing him, Prakāśānanda spoke:

46 "The Ācārya was determined to establish *advaita-vāda*, and so he explained the sūtras in another way.

47 If one accepts that He is Bhagavān (*bhagavattā*), *advaita* cannot be established. Therefore he refutes all the scriptures.

48 An author who wants to establish his own doctrine cannot give the natural meaning of the scriptures.

49 The Mīmāṁsaka says that Īśvara is a mere adjunct of karma; the Sāṅkhya says that *prakṛti* is the cause of the world.[9]

50 The Nyāya says that the universe arises from atoms. The Māyāvādī calls the impersonal Brahman the cause.

51 The Pātañjala says that Īśvara is the realisation of one's own nature. In the view of the Vedas, He is called Svayam Bhagavān, the Lord Himself.

52 Vyāsa overturned the six doctrines of the six schools, and in his sūtras he set forth the Vedānta.

53 In the view of Vedānta, Brahman is defined as having form (*sākāra*), and the word *nirguṇa*, a negation, shows that He is in truth *saguṇa* — possessed of qualities.[10]

54 None of them accepts Īśvara as the supreme cause. Each establishes his own doctrine by refuting the doctrines of others.

55 So we do not come to know the truth from the six philosophies; we accept as truth what the *mahājanas* say.

56 "Argument is inconclusive, the śrutis differ from one another, and there is no sage whose opinion does not differ from the others. The truth of dharma is hidden in the cave of the heart; the path is the one by which the great souls have gone." (Mahābhārata, Vana-parva, 313.117)[11]

57 The words of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya are a stream of nectar. Whatever He declares is the truth, the very essence."

58 Hearing all this, the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra happily went to tell the Lord.

59 At that time Mahāprabhu, having bathed at Pañcanada, was on His way to see Lord Bindu-mādhava.

60 On the way the brāhmaṇa told Him everything. Hearing it, Mahāprabhu smiled gently with pleasure.

61 Seeing the beauty of Mādhava, He was overwhelmed with feeling, and coming into the courtyard, He began to dance in love.

62 Candraśekhara, Paramānanda, Tapana and Sanātana — these four together joined in the saṅkīrtana of the holy name:

63 "*Hari haraye namaḥ, kṛṣṇa yādavāya namaḥ, gopāla govinda rāma śrī-madhusūdana*."[12]

64 On all sides hundreds of thousands of people called out, "Hari! Hari!" An auspicious sound arose, filling heaven and earth.

65 Hearing the sound of "Hari" nearby, Prakāśānanda came out of curiosity to see, bringing his disciples with him.

66 Seeing the Lord's dance, His love and the sweetness of His form, he too, with his disciples, called out, "Hari! Hari!"

67 Seeing in Him the transformations of joy, humility, restlessness and the other transient emotions (*sañcārī*), the people of Kāśī were amazed.

68 When the Lord returned to outer awareness and saw the crowds of people and the sannyāsīs, He checked His dancing.

69 The Lord honoured Prakāśānanda's feet, and Prakāśānanda came forward and clasped the Lord's feet.

70 The Lord said, "You are the guru of the world, most worthy of worship. I am not equal even to a disciple of your disciple.

71 Why should you, who are superior, honour one who is inferior? You are equal to Brahman, and your obeisance is My total ruin.

72 Although to you everything appears as Brahman, for the sake of teaching the people you should not act in this way."

73 Prakāśānanda replied, "The blasphemy of You that I committed before has all been destroyed by the touch of Your feet."

74 "Even those liberated in this life fall back into worldly desires if they offend Bhagavān, whose potencies are great and inconceivable." (a saying of the *Pariśiṣṭa*, quoted in the *Vāsanā-bhāṣya*)

75 "His sins destroyed by the touch of the Lord's beautiful feet, he gave up his serpent's body and took the form honoured by the Vidyādharas." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.34.9)[13]

76 The Lord said, "Viṣṇu! Viṣṇu! I am a tiny, lowly jīva. To regard a jīva as Viṣṇu is the mark of an offender.

77 One who thinks a jīva to be Viṣṇu, and one who regards Nārāyaṇa as equal to Brahmā and Rudra, are counted among the *pāṣaṇḍīs*.

78 'One who looks upon the Lord Nārāyaṇa as equal to Brahmā, Rudra and the other gods is surely a *pāṣaṇḍī*.'" (Vaiṣṇava-tantra; Padma-purāṇa, Uttara-khaṇḍa, 23.12)[14]

79 Prakāśānanda said, “You are Bhagavān Himself. Even so, if You think of Yourself as His servant,

80 You are still more worthy of worship than all of us. Blaspheming You has brought me total ruin.

81 “O great sage, even among millions of the liberated and the perfected, one devoted to Nārāyaṇa, whose mind is at peace, is very rare.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 6.14.5)[15]

82 “Offence against great souls destroys a man’s life, fortune, fame and dharma, his higher worlds and blessings — all that is good for him.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.4.46)[16]

83 “So long as people do not accept a bath in the dust of the feet of the great, who own nothing (*niṣkiñcana*), their minds cannot touch the feet of Urukrama, whose purpose is to remove all *anarthas*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 7.5.32)[17]

84 Now devotion to Your lotus feet will arise in me; for that I bow down at Your feet.”

85 With these words Prakāśānanda sat down there with the Lord and began to question Him:

86 “We all know now that the faults You have shown in Māyāvāda come from the Ācārya’s imagined interpretation.

87 You have explained the primary meaning of the sūtras, and hearing it, everyone’s mind was filled with wonder.

88 You are Īśvara, and all potencies are Yours. Please explain it to us briefly; I long to hear it."

89 The Lord said, "I am a jīva, and My knowledge is very meagre. The meaning of the *Vyāsa-sūtra* is deep, and Vyāsa is Bhagavān.

90 No jīva knows the meaning of his sūtras; therefore he himself has explained their meaning.

91 When the author of the sūtras himself explains them, people come to know their original meaning.

92 The meaning of the *praṇava* (*oṁ*) is contained in the Gāyatrī, and the Catuḥ-ślokī, the four essential verses, unfolds that same meaning.

93 Brahmā taught Nārada the Catuḥ-ślokī that Īśvara had spoken to him.

94 Nārada told that meaning to Vyāsa, and hearing it, Veda-vyāsa reflected within himself:

95 'This meaning accords with the explanation of my sūtras. I shall make the *Bhāgavata* the commentary on my sūtras.'[18]

96 Whatever there is in the four Vedas and the Upaniṣads, Vyāsa took its meaning and gathered it together.

97 Whatever Vedic mantra (*ṛk*) states the subject of a sūtra, that same mantra is set down in a verse of the *Bhāgavata*.[19]

98 Therefore the *Śrī Bhāgavata* is the commentary on the *Brahma-sūtra*. The verses of the *Bhāgavata* and the Upaniṣads teach one and the same doctrine.

99 “This universe and whatever moves within it are pervaded by the Lord. Enjoy what He has allotted to you, and do not covet anyone else’s wealth.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 8.1.10)

100 The *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana* of the *Bhāgavata* are clearly defined in the Catuḥ-ślokī.

101 ‘I am the truth of *sambandha*, and knowledge and realisation of Me belong to it as well. *Sādhana-bhakti*, the means of attaining Me, is called *abhidheya*.

102 The fruit of *sādhana* is prema, the chief goal (*prayojana*). By that love the jīva attains service to Me.

103 “Receive from Me, as I speak it, the supremely confidential knowledge of Myself, endowed with realisation, together with its secret and that secret’s integral part.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.30)[20]

104 I have told you these three truths. You are a jīva; you could not know these three by yourself.

105 As My form is, as My abode is, and as My qualities, deeds, six opulences and potencies are,

106 may all this be revealed to you by My mercy.’ Saying this, He told him the three truths.

107 “By My grace may you truly realise Me as I am — My being, My forms, My qualities and My deeds.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.31)[21]

108 Before creation I exist, full of the six opulences, and the manifest world (*prapañca*), *prakṛti* and the *puruṣa* lie merged in Me.

109 Having created it, I dwell within it; and all this world that you see is also I, for it is My energy.

110 At dissolution I alone remain, complete, and the material world dissolves into Me.

111 "Before creation I alone existed; there was nothing else — neither effect, nor cause, nor That which is beyond them. After creation this whole world is not other than Me, and what remains after its dissolution is also I." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.32)[22]

112 The word *aham*, 'I', appears three times in the verse *aham eva*. It establishes the existence of His form, full of all opulence.

113 This was set down to rebuke one who does not accept His form and holds Him to be formless.[23]

114 In all these words lies the discernment of jñāna and *vijñāna*: I am distinct from the works of māyā and from māyā itself.

115 Just as a reflection (*ābhāsa*) appears in place of the sun, yet has no manifestation of its own without the sun,

116 so one realises Me only on going beyond māyā. I have told you the truth of *sambandha*; now hear all the rest.

117 "Whatever appears to exist apart from Me, the Reality, and does not appear in Me, know that to be My māyā, like a reflection and like darkness." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.33)[24]

118 Now hear the consideration of *abhidheya*, *sādhana-bhakti*, which extends to all people in every place, time and circumstance.

119 In matters of dharma and the rest, people weigh the four aims of life; but *sādhana-bhakti* lies beyond all four.[25]

120 In every place, time and circumstance it is the duty of all people to ask the guru about that bhakti and to hear of it from him.

121 "This much must be inquired into by one who seeks the truth of the Self: That which exists everywhere and always, both directly and indirectly." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.35)[26]

122 Love for Me is prema, the goal (*prayojana*). I shall describe its essential nature through its effects.

123 Just as the five elements are within and without all beings, so I manifest Myself to My devotees, both within and without.[27]

124 "As the great elements enter all beings, great and small, and yet remain outside them, so I am within all that is created and yet beyond it." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.9.34)[28]

125 My devotee has bound Me in the lotus of his heart; wherever his eyes fall, there he sees Me.

126 "Hari Himself, who destroys hosts of sins even when His name is uttered helplessly, never leaves the heart of one who holds His lotus feet fast with the cord of love. Such a devotee is called the foremost of the *bhāgavatas*." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.55)[29]

127 "One who sees the Lord, the Soul of all, present in all beings, and sees all beings in the Lord, is the best of devotees (*bhāgavatottama*)." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.45)[30]

128 “Singing loudly of Him alone, the gopīs searched together from forest to forest like madwomen. They asked the trees about that Person who, like the sky, is present within and without all beings.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.30.4)

129 Therefore the *Bhāgavata* speaks of these three: it consists of *sambandha*, *abhidheya* and *prayojana*.

130 “The knowers of the Truth call the non-dual knowledge the Truth; it is named Brahman, Paramātmā and Bhagavān.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.2.11)[31]

131 This is *sambandha*. Now hear of the *abhidheya*, bhakti, whose presence pervades every verse of the *Bhāgavata*.

132 “I, the dear Self of the saintly, am attained by single-minded devotion born of faith. Devotion fixed on Me purifies even dog-eaters from the stain of their birth.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.14.21)[32]

133 Now hear of prema, the chief *prayojana*, whose signs are the thrill of rapture, tears, dancing and singing.

134 “Remembering Hari, who takes away hosts of sins, and reminding one another of Him, they bear bodies thrilled by the devotion (*prema-bhakti*) born of devotion (*sādhana-bhakti*).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.3.31)[33]

135 “One who has taken this vow, chanting the names of his beloved Lord, finds love awakening within him; his heart melts, and, heedless of the world, he laughs aloud, weeps, cries out, sings and dances like a madman.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.2.40)[34]

136 Therefore the *Bhāgavatam* is the very meaning of the sūtras: by nature it is the author's own commentary on the sūtras he himself composed.

137 "This book of eighteen thousand verses, named *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam*, is the meaning of the *Brahma-sūtras*. It settles the sense of the *Mahābhārata*, it is a commentary on the Gāyatrī, and it is enriched by the import of the Vedas." (Garuḍa Purāṇa)[35]

138 "… the very essence of essences, drawn from all the Vedas and Itihāsas." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.3.42)[3637]

139 "*Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* is held to be the essence of all Vedānta. One who is satisfied with the nectar of its rasa is never attracted to anything else." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 12.13.15)

140 This book begins with the meaning of the Gāyatrī: "*satyaṁ param*" (the Supreme Truth) is the *sambandha*, and "*dhīmahi*" (let us meditate) is both the practice (*sādhana*) and the goal (*prayojana*).[38]

141 "Let us meditate on the Supreme Truth, from whom, directly and indirectly, this universe arises, endures and dissolves; who is fully aware of all purposes and shines by Himself (*svarāṭ*); who revealed the Veda through the heart to the first poet, Brahmā; about whom even the wise are bewildered; in whom, as fire, water and earth pass into one another, the threefold creation is real; and who by His own power is ever free of all deception." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.1)[39]

142 "In this beautiful *Bhāgavatam*, composed by the great sage, is taught the supreme dharma of the saintly who are free from envy, from which all deceit has been cast out. Here is known the true Reality, which bestows good and uproots the threefold miseries. What need is there of other scrip-

tures? As soon as the pious wish to hear it, the Lord is at once captured within their hearts." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.2)[40]

143 The *Śrī Bhāgavatam* is the very form of the rasa of devotion to Kṛṣṇa; therefore its greatness surpasses that of the Vedic scriptures.

144 "O *rasikas*, O *bhāvukas* on earth! Again and again drink the *Bhāgavatam*, the ripe fruit fallen from the wish-fulfilling tree of the Vedas, filled with nectarean juice from the mouth of Śuka: drink its rasa, which embraces even the bliss of liberation." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.3)

145 "We are never satiated with the exploits of Uttamaśloka, for to those who know rasa and hear of them they grow sweeter and sweeter at every step." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.1.19)

146 Therefore study the *Bhāgavatam* carefully: from it you will gain the essential meaning of the sūtras and the śruti.

147 Always chant the name of Kṛṣṇa in saṅkīrtana: you will easily attain liberation and gain the treasure of love.[41]

148 "One who has realised Brahman and is serene within neither grieves nor desires. Equal to all beings, he attains supreme devotion to Me." (Bhagavad-gītā, 18.54)[42]

149 "Even the liberated, assuming a form (*vigraha*) by the Lord's *līlā*, worship Bhagavān." (words of the author of the Sarvajña-bhāṣya, quoted by Śrīdhara Svāmī in his commentary on Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.87.21)[43]

150 "O royal sage, although I was firmly established in transcendence of the *guṇas*, my mind was captivated by the pastimes of Uttamaśloka, and so I studied this narration." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 2.1.9)[44]

151 “The breeze that bore the fragrance of tulasī, mingled with the pollen of the lotus-eyed Lord’s lotus feet, entered their nostrils and stirred both their minds and their bodies, though they were devoted to the imperishable Brahman.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.15.43)[45]

152 ‘Even sages who delight in the ātmā and are free from the knots of the heart render causeless devotion to Urukrama, for such are the qualities of Hari.’” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 1.7.10)[46]

153 Just then the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra told the assembly how the Lord had explained that verse.

154 “The Lord has explained the meaning of this verse in sixty-one ways; all who hear it are amazed.”

155 Then everyone insisted on hearing them, and the Lord unfolded the sixty-one meanings in detail.

156 Hearing them, the people were struck with wonder and concluded that Caitanya Gosāñi is Śrī Kṛṣṇa Himself.

157 Having said this, Gaurahari rose and left, and the people bowed down to Him, calling out the name of Hari.

158 All the residents of Kāśī took up the saṅkīrtana of the Name; in love they laughed, wept, sang and danced.

159 The sannyāsīs and paṇḍitas began to study the *Bhāgavatam*. Thus the Lord delivered the city of Vārāṇasī.

160 Taking His own people with Him, the Lord came back to His lodging. Vārāṇasī had become a second Nadīyā.

161 Surrounded by His own associates, the Lord said with a smile, “I came to Kāśī to sell My wares of ecstatic feeling (*bhāva*).

162 In Kāśī there were no buyers, and the goods would not sell; yet they could not be carried back home again.

163 I would have carried the load back, but you were all grieved; so, by your wish, I have given it away free of charge.”

164 Everyone said, “You have descended to deliver the people. You have delivered the east, the south and the west.

165 Vārāṇasī alone was turned away from You; by delivering it, You have made us all happy.”

166 When the uproar arose in the town of Vārāṇasī, people from the villages and the countryside heard of it and began to come.

167 People came in hundreds of thousands, in millions, beyond counting; in that cramped place they could not get a sight of the Lord.

168 Whenever the Lord went to bathe or to see Viśveśvara, people lined both sides of the way to behold Him.

169 Raising His arms, the Lord would say, “Say ‘Kṛṣṇa!’ Say ‘Hari!’” and the people fell down before Him, calling out the name of Hari.

170 In this way the Lord delivered the people for five days; the next day He set out, His heart uneasy.

171 When the Lord rose at night and set off, five devotees followed close behind Him:

172 Tapana Miśra, Raghunātha, the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra, Candraśekhara and Paramānanda the kīrtana singer — these were the five.

173 All of them wished to go to Nīlācala with the Lord, but He took leave of them all with loving care:

174 "Whoever wishes may come later to see Me; now I shall go alone by the path through Jhārikhaṇḍa."

175 To Sanātana He said, "Go to Vṛndāvana. Your two brothers have already gone there.

176 My penniless devotees, who own only a patched quilt and a water pot — when they come to Vṛndāvana, take care of them."

177 Saying this, the Lord embraced them all and departed, and they all fell to the ground unconscious.

178 After a while they got up and returned home in sorrow, and Sanātana Gosāñi set out for Vṛndāvana.

179 Meanwhile, when Rūpa Gosāñi came to Mathurā, Subuddhi Rāya met him at Dhruva-ghāṭa.

180 Formerly, when Subuddhi Rāya was a governor (*adhikārī*) in Gauḍa, Saiyad Husain Khān was in his service.

181 Rāya put him in charge (*munsīph*) of digging a large pond; finding a fault in his work, Rāya struck him with a whip.

182 Later, when Husain Khān became king of Gauḍa, he greatly advanced Subuddhi Rāya.

183 His wife saw the marks of the whipping on his body and urged the king to have Subuddhi Rāya killed.

184 The king said, “Rāya has been my patron; he is a father to me. That I should kill him — such talk is not right.”

185 His wife said, “If you will not take his life, then take his caste.” The king said, “If his caste is taken, he will not survive.”

186 His wife threatened to die, and the king was caught in a dilemma. At last he had water from a Muslim’s water pot (*karoyā*) put into Subuddhi Rāya’s mouth.

187 Taking this as his pretext (*chadma*), Subuddhi Rāya gave up all his worldly affairs and came to Vārāṇasī.

188 He asked the paṇḍitas what atonement he should perform. They said, “Drink boiling ghee and give up your life.”

189 Another said, “Not so: the fault is slight.” Hearing this, Rāya was left in doubt.

190 Then, when Mahāprabhu came to Vārāṇasī, Rāya met Him and told Him his story.

191 The Lord said, “Go from here to Vṛndāvana and always chant the name of Kṛṣṇa in saṅkīrtana.

192 By the mere semblance of the holy name (*nāmābhāsa*) your sin and its taint will go; and by chanting the Name itself you will attain Kṛṣṇa’s feet.[47]

193 Chanting Kṛṣṇa’s name further, you will dwell in Kṛṣṇa’s abode. This is the atonement even for the greatest sins.”

194 Receiving this order, Rāya set out for Vṛndāvana and, by way of Prayāga and Ayodhyā, came to Naimiṣāraṇya.

195 Rāya stayed some days in Naimiṣāraṇya; meanwhile the Lord went from Vṛndāvana to Prayāga.

196 Coming to Mathurā, Rāya received news of the Lord; having missed meeting Him, he was deeply grieved.

197 Rāya would gather dry wood and sell it in Mathurā, earning five or six *paisā* a bundle.

198 He himself lived on one *paisā*'s worth of chickpeas and kept the rest of his money with a merchant.

199 Whenever he saw a poor Vaiṣṇava, he fed him; and when Gauḍīyas came, he gave them yogurt and rice and had them massaged with oil.

200 When Rūpa Gosāñi came, Rāya welcomed him with great affection, took him along and showed him the twelve forests.

201 Rūpa Gosāñi stayed in Vṛndāvana only a month; then he quickly set out in search of Sanātana.

202 The Lord had come to Prayāga by the path along the bank of the Gaṅgā; hearing this, the two brothers went by that same path.

203 Meanwhile Sanātana Gosāñi, having come to Prayāga, went on to Mathurā by the royal road.

204 In Mathurā Subuddhi Rāya met him and told him all the news of Rūpa and Anupama.

205 The two brothers went by the Gaṅgā path and Sanātana by the royal road; that is why he did not meet them.

206 Subuddhi Rāya showed Sanātana great affection, but Sanātana would not accept an affection rooted in worldly relationships (*vyavahāra-sneha*).

207 Supremely renounced, Sanātana wandered from forest to forest, staying night and day now under one tree, now in another grove.

208 He collected the scriptures on the glories of Mathurā and, wandering through the forests, brought the lost holy places to light.

209 Thus Sanātana stayed in Vṛndāvana, while the two brothers, Rūpa Gosāñi and Anupama, came to Kāśī.

210 There Rūpa met the three — the brāhmaṇa from Mahārāṣṭra, Candraśekhara and Tapana Miśra.

211 He lodged in Candraśekhara's house and took his meals in Miśra's house, and from Miśra he heard the teachings the Lord had given Sanātana.

212 Hearing from the three about the Lord's deeds in Kāśī, and of His mercy to the sannyāsīs, he was overjoyed.

213 Seeing the people's reverence for Mahāprabhu and hearing kīrtana from their lips, he rejoiced.

214 After staying ten days, Rūpa set out for Gauḍa. Thus I have told the story of Sanātana and Rūpa.

215 Meanwhile, as Mahāprabhu went towards Nīlādri, He felt great joy on the solitary forest path.

216 Happily the Lord journeyed on with Balabhadra and, as before, sported in many ways with the deer and other creatures.

217 Coming to Āṭhāranālā, He sent the brāhmaṇa Bhaṭṭācārya ahead to call His devotees.

218 Hearing the news, the devotees seemed to come back to life — as the senses rise up when life returns to the body.

219 Overwhelmed with bliss, the devotees came running; at Narendra lake they all met the Lord.

220 The Lord bowed at the feet of Purī and Bhāratī, and both of them embraced Mahāprabhu with love.

221 Svarūpa Dāmodara, Gadādhara Paṇḍita, Jagadānanda, Kāśīśvara, Govinda, Vakreśvara,

222 Kāśī Miśra, Pradyumna Miśra, Dāmodara Paṇḍita, Haridāsa Ṭhākura and Śaṅkara Paṇḍita —

223 these and all the other devotees fell at the Lord's feet, and the Lord, embracing them all, was overwhelmed with love.

224 All the devotees floated in an ocean of bliss. Taking them all with Him, the Lord went to see Jagannātha.

225 Seeing Jagannātha, the Lord was overwhelmed with love, and for a long time He danced and sang with the devotees.

226 A servant of Jagannātha brought a garland and prasāda and gave them to Him, and Tulasī, the *paḍichā*, came and bowed at His feet.

227 The town was in an uproar: “Mahāprabhu has come!” Sārvabhauma, Rāmānanda and Vāṇīnātha came to meet Him.[48]

228 Taking everyone with Him, the Lord came to His residence at Kāśī Miśra’s house, and Sārvabhauma and Gadādhara Paṇḍita invited Him to a meal.

229 The Lord said, “Bring the *mahā-prasāda* here: today I shall eat here with everyone.”

230 Then the two of them brought Jagannātha’s prasāda, and Mahāprabhu ate with everyone.

231 Thus I have told how the Lord, after seeing Vṛndāvana, journeyed back to Nīlādri.

232 Whoever hears this with faith will soon attain the feet of Śrī Caitanya.[49]

233 Thus I have given a brief survey of the Madhya-līlā — how for six years the Lord travelled away and came back.

234 The last eighteen years He lived in Nīlācala, enjoying the pastimes of kīrtana with His devotees.

235 Now I shall recapitulate the Madhya-līlā in order, for in recapitulation the narrative is relished anew.

236 In the First Chapter: a synopsis of the final pastimes, with some parts described in detail.

237 In the Second Chapter: a description of the Lord’s ecstatic utterances (*pralāpa*), with a brief survey of various *bhāvas*.

238 In the Third Chapter I have told of the Lord's sannyāsa and of His pastimes in the house of the Ācārya.

239 In the Fourth: the relishing of Mādhava Purī's life, the installation of Gopāla, and the story of the stolen sweet rice (*kṣīra*).

240 In the Fifth: the story of Sākṣi-gopāla, which Nityānanda told and the Lord relished.

241 In the Sixth: how the Lord delivered Sārvabhauma. In the Seventh: His pilgrimage and the deliverance of Vāsudeva.

242 In the Eighth: the conversation with Rāmānanda in detail, in which the Lord Himself heard "the essence of all conclusions."

243 In the Ninth I told of His tour of the holy places of the South; in the Tenth, of His meeting with all the Vaiṣṇavas.

244 In the Eleventh: the *beḍā-saṅkīrtana* around the Śrī Mandira; in the Twelfth: the cleaning and washing of the Guṇḍicā temple.

245 In the Thirteenth: the Lord's dancing before the chariot; in the Fourteenth: His witnessing of the Herā-pañcamī festival.

246 Within it is the hearing of the *bhāvas* of the divine maidens of Vraja: Svarūpa described them, and the Lord relished them.

247 In the Fifteenth: the Lord Himself spoke of His devotees' virtues, took a meal at Sārvabhauma's house and delivered Amogha.

248 In the Sixteenth: the journey towards Vṛndāvana by way of Gauḍa, and the return to Nīlācala from Nāṭaśālā.

249 In the Seventeenth: the journey to Mathurā by the forest path; in the Eighteenth: His wanderings in pastimes through Vṛndāvana.

250 In the Nineteenth: the journey from Mathurā to Prayāga, and within it the infusion of *śakti* into Śrī Rūpa.

251 In the Twentieth Chapter: the meeting with Sanātana, and within it a description of the nature (*svarūpa*) of Bhagavān.

252 In the Twenty-first: a description of Kṛṣṇa's majesty and sweetness; in the Twenty-second: an explanation of the two kinds of *sādhana-bhakti*.

253 In the Twenty-third: an account of the *rasas* of prema-bhakti; in the Twenty-fourth: an explanation of the meanings of the *ātmārāma* verse.

254 In the Twenty-fifth: how the residents of Kāśī were made Vaiṣṇavas, and the return from Kāśī to Nīlācala.

255 Thus I have recapitulated the twenty-five chapters; by hearing this, one relishes the meaning of the book.

256 I have told the essence of the Madhya-līlā in brief; its full extent could not be described even in millions of books.

257 To deliver the jīvas, the Lord wandered from land to land; relishing bhakti Himself, He revealed it to the world.

258 The truth of Kṛṣṇa, the truth of bhakti, the truth of prema, the truth of *bhāva*, the truth of rasa, and the essence of the truth of *līlā* —

259 these, and the truth and rasa of the *Śrī Bhāgavatam*, He preached; and He made known to the world that the *Bhāgavatam* is equal to Kṛṣṇa.

260 For the sake of His devotees He expounded these truths with His own lips; and sometimes He had His devotees speak them and listened Himself.

261 In the three worlds I see no one else as merciful, as magnanimous and as affectionate to His devotees as Śrī Caitanya.

262 O devotees, hear these pastimes with faith: by hearing them you will attain the feet of Caitanya.

263 By the grace of this *līlā* you will attain the essence of the truth of Kṛṣṇa, and here you will reach the far shore of the conclusions of all the scriptures.

264 Kṛṣṇa's *līlā* is the essence of nectar, and Caitanya's *līlā* is the inexhaustible lake from which it flows in hundreds upon hundreds of streams in all ten directions. Let the swan of your mind glide upon it.

265 O devotees, hear my humble words. Adorning my body with the dust of your feet, I lay a petition before you.[50]

266 In that lake the conclusions of devotion to Kṛṣṇa are a forest of blossoming lotuses: relish their honey. And the rasa of prema is a forest of *kumuda* lilies blooming night and day: there let the bees of your mind roam.

267 Devotees of various *bhāvas* are the swans and *cakravāka* birds who all sport in its waters, and Kṛṣṇa's pastimes are the tender lotus stalks that the devotee-swans find at all times and feed upon.

268 Go to that lake, become swans and *cakravākas*, and sport there for ever. All your sorrows will be cut away, you will attain the highest happiness, and the elation of prema will come without effort.[51]

269 The sādhus and great souls, like clouds, constantly shower this nectar on the garden of the world. From it grow nectarean fruits. The devotees feast on them without cease, and the whole world lives by the love of these devotees.

270 Caitanya's *līlā* is a filling of nectar (*amṛta-pūra*), and Kṛṣṇa's *līlā* is fine camphor; combined, the two become an exquisite sweetness. Whoever relishes it by the grace of the sādhus and the Guru knows the abundance of that sweetness.[52]

271 If a devotee takes food and drink without the nectar of this *līlā*, his life grows feeble; but by drinking a single drop of it he blossoms in body and mind, and laughs, sings and dances.

272 Drink this nectar, which has no equal, with firm faith in your heart. Do not fall into the pit of false argument, into its impure and harsh whirlpool: whoever falls there meets total ruin.[53]

273 Śrī Caitanya, Nityānanda, Śrī Advaita, the assembly of devotees, and all you devotees who listen — I make your holy feet the ornament of my head, for from them comes the fulfilment of every cherished desire.

274 Holding on my head the feet of Śrī Rūpa, Sanātana, Raghunātha and Jīva, in whom I place my hope, lowly Kṛṣṇadāsa tells a little of the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*, which is filled with the nectar of Kṛṣṇa's *līlā*.

275 For the satisfaction of Śrīman Madana-Gopāla and Govinda-deva, may this *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* be offered to Śrī Caitanya.

276 This most secret nectar of Gaura's *līlā* is surely not honoured by the common crowd: it lies beyond their reach. What loss is that to me? Relished on every side by the large-hearted and noble-minded, it increases their joy.[54]

Notes

1. The same verse as Ādi 1.18; translation as there. ↩
2. *Anubhāṣya*: leaving their study of Vedānta, the sannyāsīs gathered and spoke of the path of bhakti that Mahāprabhu had shown. ↩
3. Heading of the edition: “Bhakti alone gives liberation, and even the semblance of the name (*nāmābhāsa*) gives liberation.” ↩
4. The same verse as Madhya 22.22; translation as there. ↩
5. The same verse as Madhya 22.30; translation as there. ↩
6. *Anubhāṣya*: the *jñānī* who takes himself for a scholar, deceived by the idea that spiritual potency can have no play and that all this is a manifestation of *māyā-śakti*, mocks it. ↩
7. *Anubhāṣya*: *asat-prasaṅgaiḥ* — those attached to false arguments, absorbed in speculation on the impersonal Brahman contrary to the path of the śrutis. ↩
8. Heading of the edition: “Relying on *vivarta-vāda*, by imagined explanations of Vedānta and the Upaniṣads in a secondary sense, the asuras delude the unbelievers.” ↩
9. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Mīmāṁsakas headed by Jaimini set aside bhakti, the chief meaning of the Vedas, and made Īśvara “a part of karma”. ↩
10. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the Truth is not merely *nirguṇa*, beyond the three *guṇas*; He is a form “possessed of qualities” (*saguṇa*), the abode of countless spiritual qualities. ↩
11. The same verse as Madhya 17.186; translation as there. ↩
12. The same verse as Ādi 17.122; translation as there. ↩
13. *Anubhāṣya*: once Nanda went with his kinsmen on pilgrimage to the bank of the Sarasvatī and at night in the forest was seized by a serpent — the Gandharva Sudarśana, cursed by the sages of the Aṅgirasa line for mocking them; Kṛṣṇa touched the serpent with His foot and saved Nanda. In the edition Prakāśānanda’s words are closed after 73. ↩
14. The same verse as Madhya 18.116; translation as there. Reference as in the heading of the edition (in Madhya 18.116 — the *Vaiṣṇava-tantra* only). ↩
15. The same verse as Madhya 19.150; translation as there. ↩
16. The same verse as Madhya 15.270; translation as there. ↩
17. The same verse as Madhya 22.53; translation as there. ↩
18. In the edition Vyāsa’s thought is printed in quotation marks. ↩
19. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: the *ṛk* is a Vedic mantra, the *viṣaya-vacana* the statement of a sūtra’s subject; thus the mantra *īśāvāsyam idaṁ jagat* is set down in the *Bhāgavatam* as the verse *ātmāvāsyam idam* (99). ↩

20. The same verse as Ādi 1.51; translation as there. Numbered as in the heading of the edition (p. 835): 2.9.30; in Ādi 1.51 and in other editions — 2.9.31. ↩
21. The same verse as Ādi 1.52; translation as there. Numbered as in the heading of the edition (p. 836): 2.9.31; in Ādi 1.52 and in other editions — 2.9.32. ↩
22. The same verse as Madhya 24.72 (= Ādi 1.53); translation as there. Numbered as in the heading of the edition (p. 836): 2.9.32, as in Madhya 24.72; in Ādi 1.53 and in other editions — 2.9.33. ↩
23. *Anubhāṣya*: the arguments of the *nirviśeṣa-vādī* are full of error and must be rejected altogether; therefore the Lord said *aham eva* three times and so established *sambandha*. ↩
24. The same verse as Ādi 1.54; translation as there. Numbered as in the heading of the edition (p. 837): 2.9.33; in Ādi 1.54 and in other editions — 2.9.34. ↩
25. "These four" (*e 'cāri' vicāra*) beside *dharmādi* are, according to the *Anubhāṣya* and the *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*, the four aims of life (*catur-varga*): dharma, *artha*, *kāma* and *mokṣa*. Heading of the edition: "The *abhidheya*, *sādhana-bhakti*, is beyond the four aims (*catur-varga*)." ↩
26. The same verse as Ādi 1.56; translation as there. Numbered as in the heading of the edition (p. 837): 2.9.35; in Ādi 1.56 and in other editions — 2.9.36. ↩
27. *Anubhāṣya*: the devotees know themselves as instruments for serving Bhagavān with love, and all that is not a devotee they likewise know only as means for that service. ↩
28. The same verse as Ādi 1.55; translation as there. Numbered as in the heading of the edition (p. 837): 2.9.34; in Ādi 1.55 and in other editions — 2.9.35. ↩
29. *Anubhāṣya*: so Havi, one of the nine Yogendras, answers King Nimi on the marks of the *bhāgavatas*. ↩
30. The same verse as Madhya 8.274; translation as there. ↩
31. The same verse as Ādi 2.11; translation as there. ↩
32. The same verse as Madhya 20.138; translation as there. *Anubhāṣya*: some readings give two more verses here — Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.14.20 and 11.2.37. ↩
33. *Anubhāṣya*: so Prabuddha, one of the nine Yogendras, answers King Nimi: taking shelter at the guru's feet and performing without offence the *sādhana* of bhakti called kīrtana, the conditioned soul is freed from *anarthas* and attains *bhāva-bhakti*. ↩
34. The same verse as Ādi 7.94; translation as there. ↩
35. Heading of the edition: "The *Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* is (1) the commentary on the *Brahma-sūtra*, (2) the purport of the *Mahābhārata*, (3) the commentary on the Gāyatrī and (4) the expansion of the meaning of the Vedas." *Anubhāṣya*: as a

commentary, the *Bhāgavatam* is what the sūtras express; a variant reading adds one more verse: “Among the Purāṇas it is the Sāma; it was spoken by Bhagavān Himself; it has twelve cantos and a hundred divisions.” ↩

36. *Anubhāṣya*: this essence, drawn from all the Vedas and Itihāsas, Vyāsa gave to his son Śukadeva to study. ↩
37. Number as in the heading of the edition (p. 839): 1.3.42; 1.3.41 in the numbering of other editions. ↩
38. *Anubhāṣya*: the Supreme Truth is the *sambandha*; the effort of meditation, the practice of *sādhana-bhakti*, is the *abhidheya*; and its fruit, meditation as *prema-bhakti*, is the *prayojana*. The edition prints no numbers for verses 140–142. ↩
39. The same verse as Madhya 8.265; translation as there. ↩
40. The same verse as Ādi 1.91 (there «কিং বা»; here, as in the edition, «কিম্বা»); translation as there. The verse names no sage (*mahā-muni-kṛte*, “composed by the great sage”); the *Anubhāṣya* on Ādi 1.91 explains: Śrī Nārāyaṇa. ↩
41. Heading of the edition: “The command to chant without cease; liberation comes even from *nāmābhāsa*” (cf. 192). ↩
42. The same verse as Madhya 8.65; translation as there. ↩
43. The same verse as Madhya 24.107; translation and reference as there, following the heading of the edition (p. 841). The line is printed without a number (only «॥»). ↩
44. The same verse as Madhya 24.46; translation as there. The edition (p. 841) reads «নৈর্গুণ্যে». ↩
45. The same verse as Madhya 17.142; translation as there. ↩
46. The same verse as Madhya 6.186; translation as there. Here the Lord’s speech, begun in 89, ends; from 153 the edition resumes the narrative. ↩
47. Heading of the edition: “The fruits of *nāmābhāsa* and of the pure Name are different.” As in 30, sin is removed already by the semblance of the Name; Kṛṣṇa’s feet are attained by the Name itself. ↩
48. The first line of the verse is the second line of Madhya 16.252; that half is translated as there. ↩
49. The second line of the verse is the same as in Madhya 15.301; translated as there. ↩
50. «ধ্রুব» (in the edition «ধ্রু») after the number marks the refrain of the song. ↩
51. *Anubhāṣya*: plunging into the lake of Caitanya’s *līlā*, serve Kṛṣṇa while sheltered at Śrī Gaura’s feet; then there will be no “sorrow” — service to anyone but Kṛṣṇa — which comes to those who, like the “Nadīyā-nāgarīs”, imagine Gaurāṅga as a worldly object of enjoyment. ↩

52. *Anubhāṣya*: that abundant sweetness is tasted by one who, by the grace of the sādhus and the guru, the followers of Śrī Rūpa, knows the nectar of Gaura's *līlā* and of Kṛṣṇa's *līlā* to be one; those who separate Gaura from Kṛṣṇa (like the "Nadīyā-nāgarīs") are deprived of it. ↩
53. *Anubhāṣya*: whoever, taking the pastimes of Kṛṣṇa and Gaura to be different, yields to this whirlpool and, abandoning the service of one, serves the other, meets total ruin. ↩
54. Here the edition gives the colophon: "Thus ends the twenty-fifth chapter of the Madhya-khaṇḍa of the *Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta*: Making the Residents of Kāśī Vaiṣṇavas, and the Return to Nīlācala", and the words: "Thus the Madhya-līlā is completed." ↩